Great Barrier Reef

Great Barrier Reef is located in the North East of Australia along the East Coast of Queensland in the Pacific Ocean. It is formed by the tiny coral polyps. It is about 2300 kilometers long. It is one of the natural wonders of the world.



Great Barrier Reef



Coral Polyps

Drainage

Australia receives low average rainfall. Being a hot dry country, the rate of evaporation is high in this country. So, there is a very little amount of water left to flow as river to the seas. The River Murray and its tributary are the main rivers and a major drainage basin of Australia. This drainage basin is found in the interior part of the lowlands of Australia. It covers more than one million sq km which is about 14 per cent of area of Australia.

River Murray is the longest river in Australia. It runs 2508 km from Australian Alps to the Indian Ocean. Darling, Alexandria, Murrumbidgee, Lachlan and Swan are the other important rivers of this continent.

DO YOU KNOW?

Bourke is the place in Australia where the highest temperature is recorded (53°C). It is located in the central low lands. The lowest temperature of the country is recorded in Canberra, the capital of Australia (-22°C).

Climate

Australia contains the second largest area of extremely arid land in the world. The Tropic of Capricorn divides the Australia into two equal parts. The Northern half is in the warm tropical zone and the southern half is in the cool temperate zone. The north coastal region experiences monsoon type of climate and there is a heavy rainfall during summer. The east coastal region receives good rainfall from south east trade wind. The hot desert climate extends from central lowlands to western shores. The rainfall in this region is less than 25cm per annual. Mediterranean type of climate prevails in the southern tip of Australia in the region around Perth and Adelaide. Tasmania gets rain throughout the year from westerly winds.

Flora and Fauna

Australia is a semi-arid region. Hence, the vegetative cover is not mainly composed of trees but of scattered shrubs and herbs. Bird's eye view of Australia would reveal a very simple vegetation pattern. The plants and trees in Australia are adapted to dry conditions and can survive for long period without water. They are called **Xerophytes**. Eucalyptus is the most common tree in the west as it can withstand long period of drought. Forests and woodlands together represent about 16 per cent of the area of Australian continent. Eucalyptus, Acacia and Melaleuca (swamp forests) are the major trees of Australia.

About 80 percent of animals in this country are not found in the other parts of the world. Australia has almost 400 mammal species and about 140 species of marsupials. These are the animals that carry their young ones in their pouches. Kangaroo is the national animal of

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